farming, and there was no social security, unemployment compensation, pension plans, welfare and medicare payments, guaranteed student loans, or government-insured bank accounts. Today, manufacturing represents only 27 percent of the work force, agriculture accounts for a mere 3 percent, and the service sector, which was 12 percent in 1930, has grown steadily through recession and boom and now accounts for 70 percent of the U.S. work force. Unlike the thirties, today a large percentage of people own their own homes; many own them free and clear or have watched their equity grow substantially as property values have soared. Today, the average household has two wage earners instead of one, and that provides an economic cushion that didn't exist sixty years ago. If we have a depression, it won't be like the last one!

On weekends and weekdays I've been hearing that the country is falling apart. Our money used to be as good as gold, and now it's as cheap as dirt. We can't win wars anymore. We can't even win gold medals in ice dashes. Our brains are being drained abroad. We're losing jobs to the Koreans. We're losing cars to the Japanese. We're losing basketball to the Russians. We're losing oil to the Saudis. We're losing face to Iran.

I hear every day that major companies are going out of business. Certainly some of them are. But what about the thousands of smaller companies that are coming into business and providing millions of new jobs? As I make my usual rounds of various headquarters, I'm amazed to discover that many companies are still going strong. Some are actually earning money. If we've lost all sense of enterprise and will to work, then who are those people who seem to be stuck in rush hour?

I've even seen evidence that hundreds of these same companies have cut costs and learned to make things more efficiently. It appears to me that many of them are better off than they were in the late 1960s, when investors were more optimistic. CEOs are brighter and more heavily pressured to perform. Managers and workers understand that they have to compete.

I hear every day that AIDS will do us in, the drought will do us in, inflation will do us in, recession will do us in, the budget deficit will do us in, the trade deficit will do us in, and the weak dollar will do us in. Whoops. Make that the strong dollar will do us in. They tell me real estate prices are going to collapse. Last month people started worrying about that. This month they're worrying about the ozone layer. If you believe the old investment adage that the stock market climbs a "wall of worry," take note that the worry wall is fairly good-sized now and growing every day.

I'd developed a whole counterargument to the common argument that the trade deficit will do us in. It turns out that England had a big trade deficit for seventy years, and England was thriving around it. But there's no point bringing